

Is Malta seventh in the EU for cars per person?

Testing a media report of Eurostat's passenger-car figures against the data

THE CLAIM UNDER REVIEW

“according to the statistics Malta is ranked number seven, just between Germany and Poland respectively, with 585 cars per 1,000 inhabitants.”

Lovin Malta (J. Darmanin), 21 September 2024.

The outlet's own text, citing Eurostat; no year given for the figure.

VERDICT: LARGELY SUPPORTED

Right for 2022; the year is not stated

Version 1.0 · 6 October 2026

Status: no right of reply needed

Prepared from public sources and Eurostat data.

Repository: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien

MIŻIEN · AN INDEPENDENT FACT-CHECKING PROJECT

Contest a verdict, with evidence: github.com/leandergrech/Mizien/issues

TL;DR

On 21 September 2024 Lovin Malta reported a Eurostat dataset on passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants: **“according to the statistics Malta is ranked number seven, just between Germany and Poland respectively, with 585 cars per 1,000 inhabitants.”** The article says its rankings come from a graphic that runs “up to the year 2022”. We tested the figure, the rank and the article’s other numbers against Eurostat’s data.

- 1

The figure and the rank are right, for 2022. Eurostat gives Malta 585 passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants in 2022, seventh of the 27 Member States, between Germany (587) and Poland (584). All 27 have a 2022 value; Malta’s carries no flag [2].
- 2

The article does not say which year. It calls the dataset “as of 2023”, but its figures are 2022’s. In the 2023 figures as now published Malta is 11th (575); by 2025 it is 14th (571), below the EU-27 (584) [2].
- 3

Fewer cars per person, but more cars. From the end of 2012 to the end of 2025 Malta’s passenger car stock rose 34.5% and its population 39.6%, so the rate fell while the number of cars rose every year [3, 4].
- 4

The side remarks are loose. 585 per 1,000 is one car for every 1.7 people, not “1 car for every 2 people”. 246 km² is about the area of Malta island alone; the country has 313 km² of land. On either area Malta has by far the most cars per km² in the EU [3, 5].
- 5

Verdict: largely supported (high confidence). The reported figure and rank reproduce exactly from Eurostat. The caveats (no year, and two loosely worded side remarks) do not change the substance.



IN THIS REPORT	
1 The claim and what we could verify	6 Where the evidence points different ways
2 Method	7 Testing the claim
3 What the indicator measures	8 Verdict and requests for evidence
4 What the data show	9 Limitations
5 Population growth and car density	

1

The claim and what we could verify

The claim is Lovin Malta’s own text, read in full on 6 October 2026 on the page and through the site’s WordPress interface (post dated 21 September 2024) [1]. Lovin Malta is a news outlet and is the speaker here; the sentences below are its words, not quotations of anyone else. The article names Eurostat as the source of the dataset and a graphic by Paula Lago via The European Correspondent as the source of the rankings. We could not find the graphic (section 9).

What Lovin Malta says	Where	Access
“according to the statistics Malta is ranked number seven, just between Germany and Poland respectively, with 585 cars per 1,000 inhabitants”	Body, paragraph 3 [1]	Read in full
Eurostat “shared a dataset detailing the unit of cars per thousand residents in each European country as of 2023”; a graphic “better illustrated these rankings up to the year 2022”	Paragraphs 1–2 [1]	Read in full; graphic not found
Italy the “top-ranker ... at a whopping 682”; Latvia lowest “with only 409 per 1,000”	Paragraph 2 [1]	Read in full
“approximately 1 car for every 2 people”; “with just 246 square kilometres of land, Malta is also up there among the countries with the highest car density in Europe”	Paragraph 4 [1]	Read in full

The headline is “Malta Ranked Number Seven On Eurostat’s ‘Passenger Cars Per 1,000 Inhabitants’ Dataset”. The claim record’s summary (seventh in the EU, 585 per 1,000) matches the article; we rate the article’s own sentences, which add the neighbours (Germany, Poland) and give no year.

SCOPE NOTE

This check tests the statistics the article reports. It does not assess traffic, congestion, pollution or transport policy, which the article mentions in passing, nor the readers’ comments it summarises. Claim Check 003 covers Malta’s per-capita greenhouse gas emissions.

2

Method

Question. Was Malta seventh in the EU with 585 passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants, between Germany and Poland; for which year; and are the article’s other figures (Italy and Latvia, one car for every two people, 246 km², car density) right?

Evidence. This claim is statistical. On 6 October 2026 we downloaded through Eurostat’s API the rate itself (*road_eqs_carhab*, updated 30 July 2026) [2], the stock of passenger cars (*road_eqs_carmot*) [3], the population on 1 January (*demo_gind*) [4] and land area (*reg_area3*) [5], for every country and year, keeping Eurostat’s flags. Rank, denominator, growth and density are recomputed by *tools/cc-075-report/calc.py* from *data/cc-075/* [12]. We read Eurostat’s release of the 2022 figures (17 January 2024) [6], its two Statistics Explained articles on passenger cars and transport equipment [7, 8] and its regional releases [13]. Crossref and OpenAlex were searched for peer-reviewed work on car ownership in Malta; one comparative study was read in full [9]. Malta’s National Statistics Office (NSO) and Transport Malta refused scripted access, so their figures are second-hand (♦) [10, 11].

Grades. Official statistics and reviews are grade C under our scale. **Verdicts** follow the five-point scale in Appendix A.

3 What the indicator measures

Eurostat’s “motorisation rate” is the number of passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants [7]. A passenger car is a road motor vehicle designed to seat no more than nine people including the driver (category M1). Privately owned and company cars, taxis, private hire cars, shared cars and rented cars are included; light utility vehicles, buses and minibuses are not [7].

How the rate is built. We could not open Eurostat’s methodology page for this dataset (section 9), so we rebuilt the rate. Dividing each country’s car stock at 31 December [3] by its population on 1 January of the following year [4] reproduces Eurostat’s 2022 value for all 27 Member States, within one car per 1,000 [12]. For Malta: 317,234 cars at the end of 2022 and 542,051 people on 1 January 2023 give 585.2. Divided by the population at the start of 2022 (520,174), the same stock would give 610. The denominator therefore matters in a country whose population rose 4.2% in one year.

Registered or licensed? Eurostat collects these figures from national authorities through a questionnaire shared with the ITF and UNECE; collection methods are “not harmonised at EU level”, and vehicle registers “may include very old vehicles without signs of life” [7, 8]. For Malta, NSO publishes the stock of *licensed* motor vehicles. Its release for the end of 2022 is reported to give 424,904 licensed vehicles, 74.7% of them passenger cars, about 317,400 ♦ [10]; Eurostat’s 317,234 lies within the rounding range (317,191–317,616). NSO’s quarterly figures also count vehicles “taken off the road” (garaged, resold or scrapped) ♦ [11]. This suggests that Malta’s Eurostat figure is the licensed stock and leaves out garaged cars; we could not read NSO’s release to confirm it.

Who is counted. The denominator is the resident population [4]. Rented cars are in the numerator [7]; we found no readable source for how many of Malta’s licensed cars are rented cars.

4 What the data show

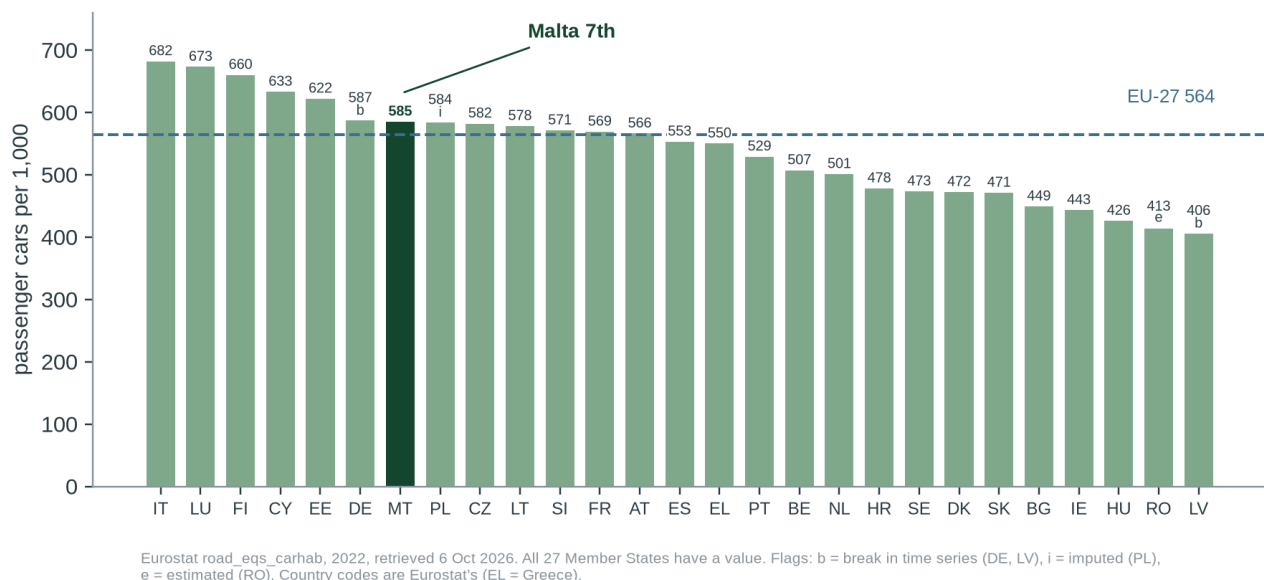


Figure 1. Passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants, 2022, all 27 Member States. Malta (585) is seventh, between Germany (587, break in series) and Poland (584, imputed by Eurostat); Czechia (582) is three cars behind. The EU-27 value is 564 [2].

Indicator	Malta	Comparison	Source	Grade
Passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants, 2022	585 (no flag)	EU-27 564	Eurostat [2]	C
Rank among the EU-27, 2022	7th of 27	Germany 587 (b), Poland 584 (i)	Eurostat [2]	C
Rank among all 41 countries in the dataset, 2022	9th	Liechtenstein 773, Iceland 611 (i) higher	Eurostat [2]	C
Highest and lowest in the EU-27, 2022	–	Italy 682; Latvia 406 (b)	Eurostat [2]	C
Same, in Eurostat's release of 17 Jan 2024	not given	Italy 684; Latvia 414; EU 560	Eurostat [6]	C
Rank, 2023 / 2024 / 2025	11th / 13th / 14th	Malta 575 / 576 / 571; EU-27 570 / 577 / 584	Eurostat [2]	C
Car stock at 31 Dec 2022 vs NSO licensed passenger cars	317,234	about 317,400 ♦	Eurostat [3]; NSO [10]	C

Flags: b = break in time series, i = imputed by Eurostat or other receiving agencies. All values in data/cc-075/checks.csv [12]. In 2025, eleven countries' values are flagged (provisional, estimated, imputed or break); Malta's values carry no flag in any year.

Malta's rank over time

Malta's rate rose from 302 in 1990 to a peak of 616 in 2016, and has drifted down since. Its rank in the EU-27 was third in eleven years (1995, 1997, 2007–2012 and 2014–2016), seventh in 2022, and 14th in 2025, when it fell 13 cars per 1,000 below the EU-27 value (Figure 2) [2]. The EU-27 value meanwhile rose from 487 in 2010 to 584 in 2025 [2]. A 2010 comparative study of four island states described Malta's car ownership as then “the highest in the European Union” [9]; it used a different measure and earlier data, and in Eurostat's current series Malta was third in those years.

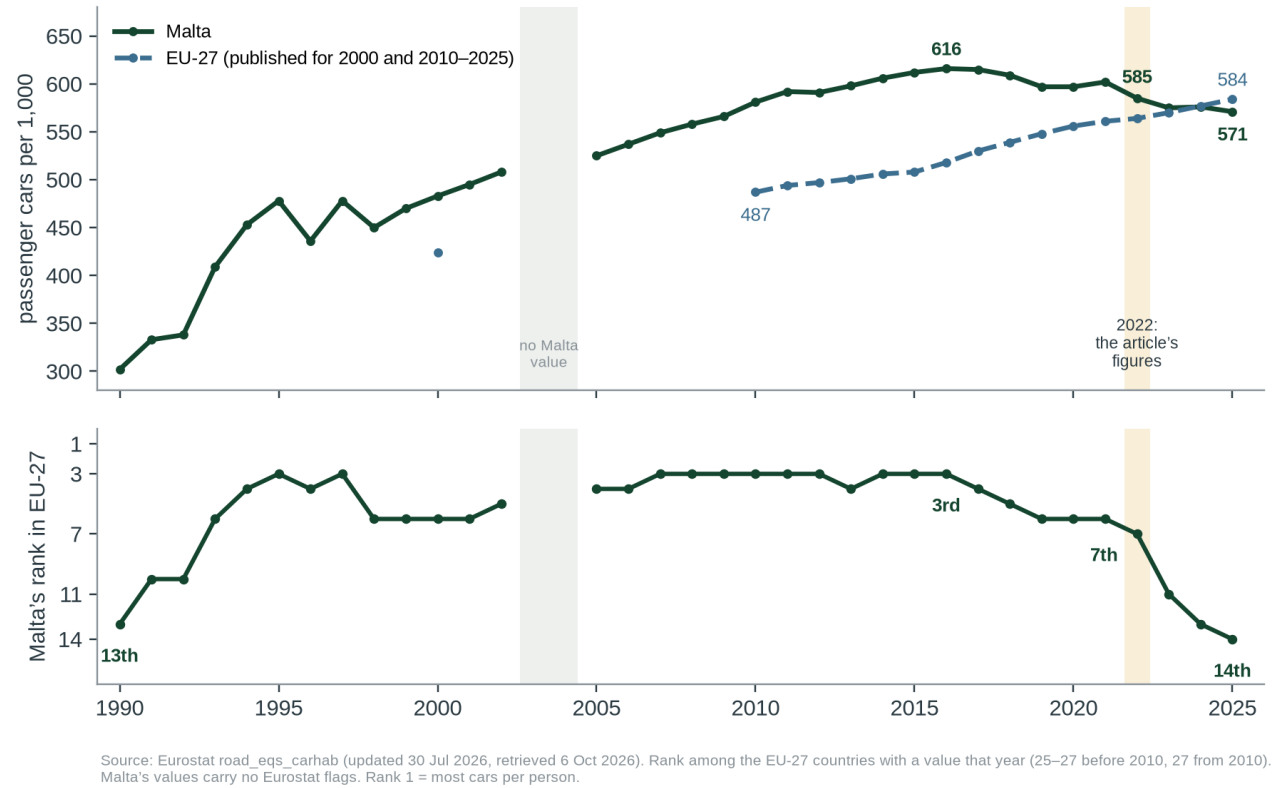


Figure 2. Top: passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants, Malta and EU-27, 1990–2025. Bottom: Malta's rank among the EU-27 countries with a value each year. The shaded band marks 2022, the year the article's figures match. No Malta value for 2003–2004 [2].

5 Population growth and car density

The fall in the rate is a population effect. Malta's passenger car stock grew every year from 2006 to 2025 [3]: by 6,618 in 2023, 6,632 in 2024 and 5,209 in 2025. Its population grew faster: from the end of 2012 to the end of 2025 the car stock rose 34.5% (249,612 to 335,693) and the population 39.6% (421,464 to 588,254) [3, 4]. In 2022 alone the stock rose 1.3% and the population 4.2%, which is why the rate dropped from 602 to 585 in the year the article reports (Figure 3).

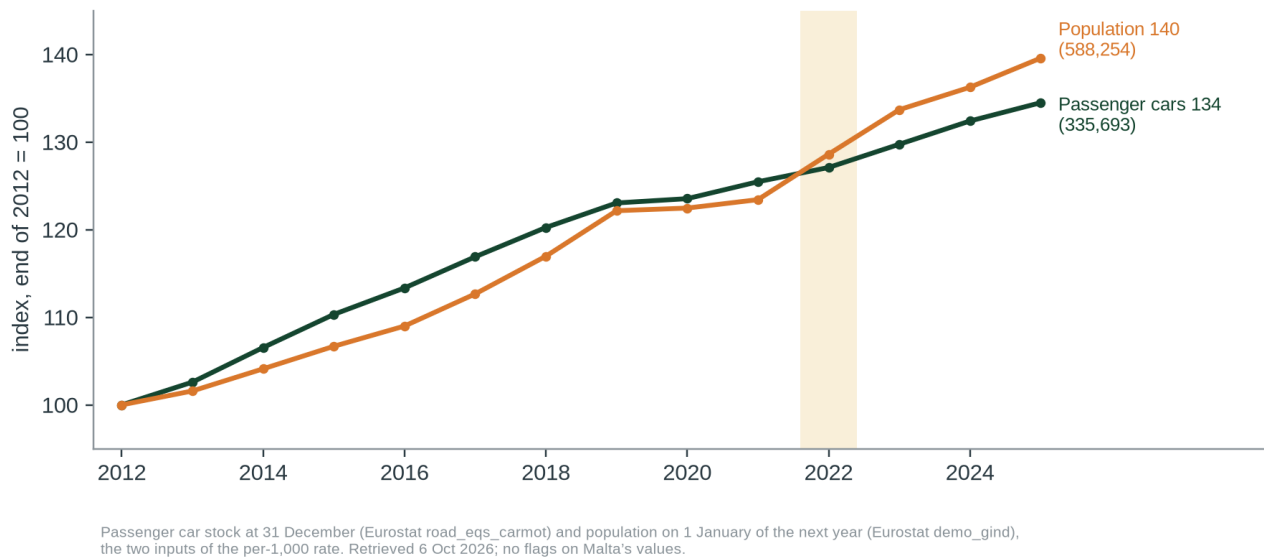


Figure 3. Malta's passenger car stock and population, indexed to the end of 2012. The population index passes the car-stock index in 2022, the year of the article's figures; from 2022 to 2025 the population grew 8.5% and the car stock 5.8% [3, 4].

Measured per km² of land instead of per person, Malta is far ahead of every other Member State: 1,014 passenger cars per km² in 2022 against 261 in the Netherlands, the next highest, and 1,073 in 2025 [3, 5]. The article's 246 km² is Malta island (245 km² of land in Eurostat's data); the whole country, including Gozo and Comino, has 313 km² [5]. Using Malta island alone with the national car stock would give 1,295 cars per km², an overstatement, but the article did not compute a density, and its sentence (Malta "up there among the countries with the highest car density") holds on either area.

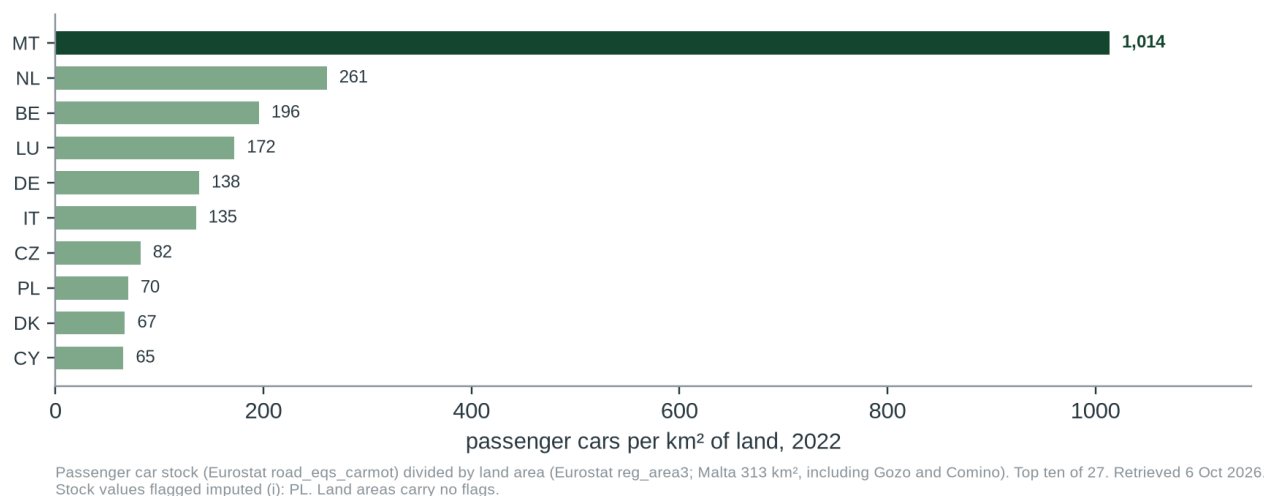


Figure 4. Passenger cars per km² of land, 2022, the ten highest of the EU-27 [3, 5].

6

Where the evidence points different ways

Q1 Was “seventh” the current picture when the article appeared?

TRUE FOR 2022; LATER DATA DIFFER

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

2022 is the year of the graphic the article used and of Eurostat’s own release of 17 January 2024 [6]. Eurostat’s regional releases came on 6 May 2024 (for 2022) and 21 May 2025 (for 2023) [13]. The article’s Italy figure (682) matches the 2022 data.

EVIDENCE AGAINST

The article gives no year for the 585 and describes the dataset as “as of 2023”. In the 2023 figures as now published Malta is 11th (575); by 2025 it is 14th, below the EU-27 [2]. A reader in September 2024 could take seventh as the current position.

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: we could not establish whether any 2023 values were in Eurostat’s dataset on 21 September 2024 (section 9). On the evidence we have, the article reported a correct 2022 figure without saying it was 2022. That is a caveat, not an error in the figure.

Q2 Are the national figures comparable enough to rank?

RANK HOLDS; MARGINS ARE SMALL

EVIDENCE FOR THE CLAIM'S IMPRESSION

Eurostat publishes the rates side by side and ranks them in its own releases [6, 7]. Malta’s values carry no flag, and its car stock matches NSO’s licensed passenger cars ♦ [3, 10].

EVIDENCE AGAINST

Collection methods are “not harmonised at EU level” and registers may hold cars with no “signs of life” [7]. If Malta counts only licensed cars while some countries’ registers hold inactive ones, Malta’s rate is understated relative to theirs; we cannot measure by how much. Germany’s 2022 value has a break in series and Poland’s is imputed [2].

WHY THEY DIFFER, AND WHAT IT MEANS HERE

For this claim: the article reports Eurostat’s published ranking accurately. Places 6 to 9 are within five cars per 1,000 (Germany 587, Malta 585, Poland 584, Czechia 582), so the exact position is less robust than the broad picture of Malta among the EU’s higher rates in 2022.

7

Testing the claim

Sub-claim	What the evidence shows	Rating
A. Malta has 585 cars per 1,000 inhabitants	Eurostat 2022: 585, no flag; reproduced from 317,234 cars and 542,051 people on 1 Jan 2023 [2–4].	ACCURATE (2022)
B. Ranked number seven, between Germany and Poland	Seventh of 27, all reporting; Germany 587 (break in series), Poland 584 (imputed) [2]. An EU ranking: among all 41 countries in the dataset Malta is ninth.	ACCURATE (2022)
C. The year: a dataset “as of 2023”, a graphic “up to the year 2022”	The figures are 2022’s; the article never says so. In the 2023 figures as now published Malta is 11th (575) [2]; whether they were out by 21 Sep 2024 could not be established.	YEAR NOT STATED
D. Italy top at 682, Latvia lowest at 409	Italy 682 and Latvia lowest match [2]. Latvia is 406 (break in series) now and was 414 in Eurostat’s January 2024 release [6].	LARGELY ACCURATE
E. “Approximately 1 car for every 2 people”	585 per 1,000 is one car for every 1.71 people [2]; the rounding understates the rate.	LOOSELY WORDED
F. 246 km² of land; among the highest car density in Europe	246 km² is Malta island; the country has 313 km² of land [5]. With 1,014 cars per km² of land Malta is first in the EU, 3.9 times the Netherlands [3, 5].	LARGELY ACCURATE

The central statement (A, B) reproduces exactly from Eurostat’s current data for 2022, the year of the graphic the article used. **The year (C)** is the main caveat: “as of 2023” describes the dataset, while the figures are 2022’s, and the article never ties the 585 to a year. **The side remarks (D–F)** are right in direction: Latvia’s figure differs by data vintage; “1 car for every 2 people” understates Malta’s rate; and 246 km² is the main island, though Malta leads the EU on car density on either area.

8

Verdict and requests for evidence

VERDICT

LARGELY SUPPORTED

The figure and the rank reproduce exactly from Eurostat for 2022; the article gives no year and two side remarks are loose. Confidence: high.

Why. (1) Malta’s 585 passenger cars per 1,000 inhabitants and its seventh place among the 27 Member States, between Germany and Poland, match Eurostat’s data for 2022, in which all 27 report and Malta’s value carries no flag. (2) The article does not say the figures are for 2022 and calls the dataset “as of 2023”; in the 2023 figures as now published Malta is 11th. (3) Its Italy and Latvia figures, its “1 car for every 2 people” and its 246 km² are approximately right, and its car-density sentence is accurate. These caveats do not change the substance. (4) Confidence is high because the rate rebuilds from Eurostat’s stock and population data for all 27 countries, and Eurostat’s own release gives the same picture for 2022.

What this verdict does not say. It does not say Malta is seventh today (it was 14th in 2025), that Malta has more cars than before (the stock has grown every year), or anything about congestion, pollution or transport policy. It assesses only whether Lovin Malta reported Eurostat’s figures accurately.

Evidence we are asking for

- ☐ From Lovin Malta: the graphic it used (Paula Lago, The European Correspondent) and the date of the data in it.
- ☐ From Eurostat: the date on which 2023 values were first published in *road_eqs_carhab*, and its methodology note on how national stocks are counted.
- ☐ From NSO or Transport Malta: the stock of licensed passenger cars by year, the number of rented cars in it, and the number of registered but unlicensed (garaged) cars.

Right of reply. Not needed: under the project’s rule a reply is sought only for Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted verdicts.

9

Limitations

- Eurostat serves only its current data. We could not see the dataset as it stood on 21 September 2024: the Internet Archive lists a February 2024 copy of Eurostat’s passenger-car article, but web.archive.org reset every connection from our network. Several 2022 values have been revised since January 2024 (Cyprus 658 to 633, Luxembourg 678 to 673) [2, 6].
- The graphic the article used (Paula Lago, The European Correspondent) was not found; the Instagram post embedded in the article needs a login.
- Eurostat’s methodology (ESMS) page for road equipment returned “not found” at every address we tried; the denominator was established by recomputation instead.
- NSO and Transport Malta refused scripted access. The licensed-vehicle figures [10, 11] are second-hand (♠); Newsbook’s passenger-car counts are internally inconsistent and are not used.

- We found no readable count of rented cars in Malta's licensed stock, so their effect on a per-resident rate is not quantified.
- Warren and Enoch [9] is a comparative study with data from the 2000s and a different measure; it is context only.

References

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- [2] Eurostat. road_eqs_carhab Passenger cars – per thousand inhabitants; updated 30 Jul 2026, retrieved 6 Oct 2026, with flags. doi:10.2908/ROAD_EQS_CARHAB. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/road_eqs_carhab/default/table?lang=en
- [3] Eurostat. road_eqs_carmot Passenger cars, by type of motor energy and size of engine (total); updated 1 Sep 2026, retrieved 6 Oct 2026, with flags. doi:10.2908/ROAD_EQS_CARMOT. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/road_eqs_carmot/default/table?lang=en
- [4] Eurostat. demo_gind Population change – demographic balance and crude rates at national level (population on 1 January); updated 30 Sep 2026, retrieved 6 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/demo_gind/default/table?lang=en
- [5] Eurostat. reg_area3 Area by NUTS 3 region (land area); updated 22 Jan 2026, retrieved 6 Oct 2026. https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/databrowser/view/reg_area3/default/table?lang=en
- [6] Eurostat (17 Jan 2024). Passenger cars per 1 000 inhabitants reached 560 in 2022. Eurostat news. Read 6 Oct 2026. <https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/web/products-eurostat-news/w/ddn-20240117-1>
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- [11] ♦ Balzan J. (30 Jul 2025). Over 450,000 licensed vehicles on Malta's roads, NSO confirms. Newsbook (a report of NSO's Q2/2025 release). Read 6 Oct 2026. <https://newsbook.com.mt/en/over-450000-licensed-vehicles-on-maltas-roads-nso-confirms/>
- [12] Mizien. Data and calculations: data/cc-075/; tools/cc-075-report/calc.py.
- [13] Eurostat (6 May 2024; 21 May 2025). Passenger cars per inhabitant remain stable in 2022; Passenger cars per inhabitant stable in 2023. Eurostat news (regional data). Read 6 Oct 2026. <https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/web/products-eurostat-news/w/ddn-20250521-1>

Appendix A: series standards and verdict scale

Every investigation in this series follows the same rules so that verdicts are comparable and challengeable.

Verdict	Meaning
SUPPORTED	Evidence consistently backs the claim as stated.
LARGELY SUPPORTED	Backed by the evidence, with minor caveats that do not change the substance.
NOT SUBSTANTIATED	Stated more strongly than the evidence offered or available allows. May be true in some conditions but has not been shown.
MISLEADING	Omits material facts so that the overall impression is inaccurate, even if individual statements are defensible.
CONTRADICTED	The available evidence points against the claim.

Confidence

High: multiple independent lines of evidence agree. **Moderate:** evidence is relevant but incomplete or indirect. **Low:** evidence is thin, second-hand or conflicting.

Evidence grades

A experiment · B observational study with a control or gradient · C review, guidance or official statistics · D assertion or anecdote. ♦ marks a source known only second-hand.

Standards

- **Quote the speaker, not the headline**, with outlet and date, and link the original where possible.
- **Separate the claim from the evidence offered for it**, and say who made which statement.
- **Grade the evidence** and show differing views side by side where the evidence is unsettled.
- **State what we could not access or verify**, and what would change the verdict either way.
- **Ask for the missing evidence** in specific, answerable requests.
- **Offer a right of reply** where a check finds a claim Not substantiated, Misleading or Contradicted (or a pledge Not measurable, Off track or Missed), before wider circulation, and append responses.
- **Correct errors openly** with a version number and change log.
- **Whistle-blow only on evidence:** a verdict of *Misleading* or *Contradicted* requires documents or data that can be shown, not inference.
- **Check every side.** Government, opposition, NGOs and developers are held to the same standard.

Appendix B: revision log

Version	Date	Change
1.0	6 Oct 2026	First issue. No right of reply needed for a Largely supported verdict.